

The Impact of Tribalism on the Role of Intellectuals in Somalia

A Public Administration Perspective

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Abstract

This article examines how entrenched clan-based politics shape the role, autonomy, and institutional effectiveness of intellectuals in Somalia. Drawing on perspectives from public administration and African political sociology, the study argues that the institutionalization of tribalism—most notably through the 4.5 power-sharing formula—has transformed intellectual engagement from a merit-based professional role into a politically negotiated clan identity. Using qualitative conceptual analysis, the article introduces the concept of Global Tribalism to explain how diaspora networks, digital platforms, and transnational political engagement reinforce local patronage systems. The findings demonstrate that tribalized governance undermines meritocracy, marginalizes qualified women, weakens ethical accountability, and accelerates intellectual brain drain. The article concludes that sustainable state-building in Somalia requires a deliberate separation of clan identity from public administration through merit-based recruitment, institutional protection of intellectuals, and a civic reorientation toward service delivery rather than clan entitlement. By situating Somalia's experience within broader African debates on governance and legitimacy, the article contributes to African Studies scholarship on post-conflict state formation and the politics of knowledge.

Keywords: Tribalism; Intellectuals; Public Administration; State-Building; Somalia; African Governance

1. Introduction

In post-conflict societies, intellectuals play a central role in reconstructing institutions, shaping public discourse, and legitimizing governance frameworks. As producers of knowledge and custodians of professional norms, intellectuals are expected to contribute to rational policymaking and institutional development. In Somalia, however, the capacity of intellectuals to perform this role has been severely constrained by the entrenchment of clan-based politics within state structures.

Historically, Somali clan systems functioned as mechanisms of social protection, conflict mediation, and collective security. In the contemporary political arena, however, tribalism has evolved into an administrative logic governing access to public office, resource allocation, and political representation. This transformation has redefined intellectual engagement from a merit-driven professional function into a negotiated identity role mediated by clan affiliation.

This article examines how tribalized governance reshapes the role of intellectuals in Somalia. It argues that the institutionalization of clan politics has undermined meritocracy, eroded ethical accountability, marginalized women intellectuals, and accelerated brain drain. By situating Somalia within broader African governance debates, the study contributes to African Studies scholarship on state-building, legitimacy, and the politics of knowledge.

2. Literature Review: Intellectuals, Tribalism, and Governance in Africa

African Studies scholarship has long emphasized the importance of intellectuals in mediating relations between society and the state. Intellectuals have historically been viewed as nation-builders responsible for articulating developmental visions and legitimizing political authority (Mazrui 1978). However, subsequent studies have highlighted the ambivalent position of intellectuals within neopatrimonial and clientelist states, where access to influence is often mediated through informal political networks (Bayart 1993).

Scholars such as Mkandawire (2015) argue that the marginalization of autonomous intellectual labor in Africa has weakened policy innovation and institutional learning. Instead

of functioning as independent critics or reformers, intellectuals are frequently absorbed into patronage systems that reward loyalty over expertise.

The role of identity politics in African governance has also been widely documented. While ethnicity and clan affiliation historically served social and cultural functions, their politicization has transformed governance into a competitive struggle for state resources (Lonsdale 1994; Posner 2005). When institutionalized within the state, identity-based politics undermine bureaucratic rationality and weaken public accountability.

In the Somali context, scholars such as Lewis (2002) and Samatar (2010) demonstrate that clan identity remains the primary axis of political organization. The formalization of clan representation through mechanisms such as the 4.5 power-sharing formula has entrenched tribalism as an administrative principle. However, limited attention has been paid to how these dynamics shape the professional role of intellectuals themselves. This article addresses that gap by foregrounding intellectuals as institutional actors whose authority and autonomy are structurally conditioned by tribalized governance.

3. Theoretical Framework: Meritocracy, Tribalized Governance, and Global Tribalism

This study is grounded in a theoretical tension between meritocratic public administration and tribalized governance. Meritocracy prioritizes professional competence, institutional ethics, and impersonal rules as the basis for recruitment and decision-making (Weber 1978; Olowu 2012). In contrast, tribalized governance privileges identity, lineage, and political loyalty.

In Somalia, clan identity has become formally embedded within governance structures, recalibrating intellectual authority. Professional credentials alone are insufficient; legitimacy increasingly depends on one's ability to represent clan interests. This creates structural incentives for intellectuals to align with clan-based patrons, compromising professional neutrality.

A central conceptual contribution of this article is the introduction of Global Tribalism. Existing literature often treats tribalism as a localized phenomenon. This study argues that tribalism has been globalized through diaspora networks, digital communication, and transnational political engagement. Diaspora intellectuals, despite operating within merit-based systems abroad, frequently reproduce clan-centered political narratives when engaging with Somali politics. Through funding channels, advocacy networks, and online mobilization,

they reinforce tribalized governance structures. Global Tribalism thus refers to the transnational reproduction of identity-based governance norms that undermine meritocracy in fragile states.

4. Analysis: Systemic Effects of Tribalized Governance

4.1 Gender Marginalization

Tribalized governance structures are inherently patriarchal. Representation is typically mediated through male clan elders, limiting institutional space for women intellectuals regardless of their qualifications. As a result, women's participation in governance remains symbolic, depriving public institutions of inclusive leadership and innovation.

4.2 Ethical Erosion and Accountability Deficits

Clan affiliation often functions as a protective shield against professional scrutiny. Intellectuals aligned with dominant clans may face limited accountability, even in cases of incompetence or corruption. This dynamic erodes ethical standards and weakens public trust in both intellectual authority and state institutions.

4.3 Brain Drain and Institutional Hollowing

The absence of merit-based career pathways has driven many qualified intellectuals toward international organizations or permanent migration. This persistent brain drain hollows out domestic institutions, reinforcing dependency on external expertise and undermining long-term state capacity.

4.4 Reconfiguration of Intellectual Authority

Collectively, these dynamics transform intellectual authority from a professional role into a negotiated identity function. Intellectuals become intermediaries of clan interests rather than independent agents of reform.

5. Policy Implications and Reform Strategies

5.1 De-politicization of the Civil Service

The introduction of a National Competitive Examination for public-sector recruitment would reduce patronage and strengthen meritocracy.

5.2 Institutional Protection of Intellectuals

Independent academic associations and professional unions should be strengthened to protect intellectual autonomy and ethical standards.

5.3 Civic Reorientation

Public discourse must shift from clan entitlement toward service delivery, accountability, and institutional performance.

6. Conclusion

Tribalism remains a social reality in Somalia, but its fusion with public administration has proven institutionally corrosive. By embedding clan identity into governance structures, the state has constrained intellectual autonomy, undermined meritocracy, and weakened institutional capacity. Through the concept of Global Tribalism, this article highlights how transnational political engagement can reinforce identity-based governance norms.

Sustainable state-building in Somalia depends on the ability of intellectuals to transcend clan loyalty and reassert the primacy of professional competence, ethical accountability, and public service.

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